



Monolith

Brand Guide v1 · August 2026

1 The idea

A monolith is a single enormous stone. You can see it from miles away. You orient yourself by it. It outlasts you.

Most years dissolve. Fifty-two weeks of meetings, errands, and weekends that blur into one another, and by December you can't say what happened. A monolith is the thing that refuses to dissolve — the one commitment big enough that no matter what else the year holds, that's the thing you'll tell people about.

Monolith is a one-page year planner built around that single idea: place the biggest stone first, then build the rest of the year around it.

The product is a wall calendar — the entire year on one sheet, every day visible at once. But the calendar is the artifact, not the point. The point is that you can only see the shape of a year when you can see all of it at the same time.

2 Who it's for

Primary: People who already believe their time is finite and are frustrated that their calendar doesn't reflect it. They set annual intentions. They've heard of misogi, or 12-week years, or big rocks. They're already trying — they just don't have a surface that holds a whole year.

Typically 28–50, disposable income, some combination of endurance sport, entrepreneurship, or creative work. They buy physical objects on purpose. They print things.

Secondary: Couples and families coordinating a year — the trip, the move, the wedding, the sabbatical — who need one shared view rather than five overlapping Google Calendars.

Not for: People looking for a task manager, a productivity system, or daily scheduling. Monolith operates at the altitude of years, not hours. Anyone who wants to optimize their Tuesday is in the wrong place.

3 Positioning

For people who don't want another forgettable year, Monolith is a one-page annual planner that makes you commit to one defining thing and build the rest of the year around it. Unlike task apps that manage your days, Monolith operates at the scale of a whole life — because you only get about eighty of these.

What we compete with: not Notion or Todoist. We compete with the vague sense that another year got away.

Three things we promise

See the whole year. Not a month at a time. All 365 days, at once, on a wall.

Commit to one big thing. The misogi. The monolith. One item that defines the year.

Look back and see something. By December the calendar is a record, not a plan.

4 Brand pillars

Finite

We never pretend time is abundant. The product's emotional engine is scarcity — a limited number of years, each one visible in full. We state this plainly and without melodrama.

Massive

Everything about the brand is scaled up. Big type. Big claims. Big stone. The opposite of the fussy, feature-listing productivity category.

Earned

A monolith is raised, not bought. Language is about effort, weight, and consequence. Nothing is easy, effortless, or frictionless — those are other brands' words.

Still

Stone doesn't hurry. The tone is calm and declarative, never urgent or hype-driven. Confidence, not caffeine.

5 Voice

We sound like: someone stating an obvious truth you'd been avoiding. Short sentences. Concrete nouns. No throat-clearing.

We do not sound like: a hustle podcast, a meditation app, or a SaaS changelog.

Rules

- Declaratives over questions. "Place the big stone first." not "Ready to place your big stone?"
- Second person, present tense.
- Specific over abstract. "Run 100 miles." not "Achieve your fitness goals."
- No exclamation points. Ever.
- No emoji in brand-voice copy.
- Never use: journey, unlock, empower, effortless, game-changer, level up, crush it, 10x, seamless.

- Numbers are allowed to be blunt. "You get about eighty of these."

Examples

Instead of	Write
Ready to make 2027 your best year yet?	2027 is 365 days. Here they all are.
Set ambitious goals and track your progress!	Choose one thing you might fail at.
Our intuitive interface makes planning easy	The whole year fits on one page.
Unlock your potential	Most of your capacity is unused. This is the year you find out.
You did it! 🎉	Monolith raised.

Boilerplate (50 words)

Monolith is a one-page year planner. You choose one defining commitment — the thing that makes the year worth remembering — and build everything else around it. The whole year lives on a single sheet, so you can see it coming and, in December, see what it was.

Elevator line

It's the whole year on one page, organized around the one thing you'll actually remember.

6 Vocabulary

Use these words consistently. They are the product's grammar.

Term	Meaning
Monolith	The single defining commitment of the year. One per year. Never plural for one person.
Raise	The verb for committing to a monolith. "Raise your monolith." Completion is "raised."
Boulders	The other large, immovable commitments — the trip, the move, the race, the launch.
The wall	The calendar itself, especially the printed edition.
The year at a glance	The core capability. Use plainly, don't dress it up.
Misogi	Used for the audience that already knows it. Always explained on first use for everyone else. Monolith is the plain-English translation.

One monolith per year. This is a rule, not a suggestion, and the product should enforce it. The constraint is the product. If people can raise five, they'll raise five, and none of them will mean anything.

7 Taglines

One year. One monolith.

Alternates

- Place the big stone first.
- You get about eighty of these.
- Build something you'll remember.
- The year, in one piece.
- Most years disappear. Not this one.

Campaign line (January): What's your monolith?

8 Visual direction

Logo

The mark is the thing itself: a single solid vertical rectangle, ratio roughly 1:2.6, flat obsidian, no gradient, no bevel, no outline. It reads as a standing stone, a calendar tile, and a period at the end of a sentence all at once.

It scales to anything — favicon, app icon, bullet point, list marker, the misogi tile inside the calendar grid. That last use is the important one: the logo and the product's core feature are the same shape.

Wordmark: MONOLITH set in all caps, heavy weight, tight tracking (-1% to -2%), no letterspacing flourish. The word is already long and imposing; let it be.

Lockup: mark to the left of the wordmark, optically aligned, with the mark's height matching cap-height plus a small overshoot so it stands slightly taller than the letters.

Color

The brand is stone and bone. Category colors inside the calendar carry all the chroma; the brand itself stays neutral so it never fights the content.

Role	Name	Hex
Primary	 Obsidian	#12100E
Secondary	 Basalt	#2A2724
Mid	 Slate	#6E6A63
Surface	 Limestone	#F4F1EA
Surface alt	 Bone	#FBFAF7
Line	 Ash	#DDD8CE
Accent (sparing)	 Ochre	#C8873B

Rules

- Obsidian on Limestone is the default pairing. Not pure black on pure white — the warmth matters.
- Ochre appears only on the monolith itself: the raised state, the one call-to-action that matters. If ochre is on screen twice, one of them is wrong.
- Category colors (adventures red, occasions yellow, trips blue, career green, bucket list grey) live inside the grid only. Never in brand chrome.

Typography

- **Display / wordmark:** a tight, heavy grotesk. Paid: Söhne Kräftig, Neue Haas Grotesk Display 75. Free: Archivo Expanded 700, Inter Tight 800.
- **Editorial moments:** a high-contrast serif for the one big statement per page — the "you get about eighty of these" line. Free: Instrument Serif. Paid: GT Sectra Display.
- **Interface and body:** Inter, or system stack. Neutral on purpose.
- **Data / grid:** tabular figures, always. Dates must align in columns.

Scale is the main tool. Headlines should be uncomfortably large — 72px+ on desktop hero. Body copy stays small and calm. The contrast between them is the whole visual idea: something enormous, and the ordinary life arranged around it.

Layout

- Generous margins. Stone needs space around it or it's just a brick.
- Left-aligned, ragged right. No centered paragraphs.
- Hard edges. Border radius 0–2px. No soft shadows, no glassmorphism, no gradients.
- One idea per screen.

Imagery

Photography leans geological and vast: standing stones, quarry faces, sea cliffs, desert monoliths, ice. Cold light, no people in hero images — the viewer is the person in the landscape.

Avoid entirely: stock photos of smiling planners, laptops on desks, sticky notes, whiteboards, sunrise-with-arms-raised.

The strongest image in the whole system is a photograph of the printed calendar on a real wall in a real room. Lead with that more than you think you should.

9 Applications

The product (web). Grid stays quiet — Limestone ground, Ash gridlines, category colors as small solid chips. The monolith tile is the exception: full-height, Obsidian fill, ochre label. It should look like something dropped into the year from a different weight class.

The print. Large format, matte, heavy stock. Sold as the year's object, not a printout. This is where margin lives and where the brand becomes physical. Ship it in a tube, not a flat envelope.

Empty state. Before a monolith is raised, its slot is an outlined rectangle with a single line of copy: "Nothing here yet. That's the problem."

Completion. When it's done, the tile fills solid and the interface says Monolith raised. Nothing else. No confetti.

January campaign. One question, everywhere: What's your monolith? Landing page is a single field and a photograph of a wall.

Email. Quarterly, not weekly. Each one shows the year so far as an image and asks one question. If there's nothing worth saying, don't send.

10 Guardrails

Monolith is not:

- a task manager, habit tracker, or daily planner
- a social network — other people's monoliths are inspiration, never leaderboards
- gamified. No streaks, points, badges, or nudges. A monolith you were nagged into isn't one.
- optimistic by default. We're honest that most people won't finish, and that trying is still the point.

On failure. Roughly half of monoliths should fail. That's the design — a goal you're certain to hit was too small. The brand must never punish failure or hide it. A monolith attempted and missed still shaped the year, and the product should let you write down what happened.

On misogi. Credit the concept where relevant; don't cosplay the ritual. Misogi is a real Shinto practice, and the modern goal-setting usage is a borrowing. Reference it with a light hand, explain it plainly, and don't decorate the brand with Japanese visual motifs.

11 Relationship to Cairn Year

If Cairn Year remains the product name, Monolith becomes the sub-brand for the single defining commitment — the word for the feature, the visual treatment of that tile, and the name of the premium print (Monolith Edition). Everything in sections 6, 8, and 9 still applies, scoped to that feature.

Pick one as master. Two names of equal weight means neither one sticks.

12 Open questions

- Does the monolith get placed on a date or span a range? A date makes it an event; a range makes it a campaign. This changes the grid design.
- Is the print a derivative of the web app, or the primary product the app supports?
- Do people see others' monoliths? Real inspiration value, real dilution risk.
- What happens on December 31st? The transition from plan to record is the most important moment in the product and currently has no design.